PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Suzuki SJ / Samurai

1981–1998 · SJ410 · SJ413 · Samurai · JA51

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust and hidden trail damage**
  MotorTrend's advice is to check the underbody carefully, for rust and also for dents, scrapes and dried mud in hard-to-reach places, which all point to a hard off-road life. If you want a stock truck, an unmodified Samurai is less likely to have been abused.
- [ ] **Transfer case mounts and frame hangers**
  Trail Tough calls cracked transfer case mounts and a wallowed-out, bent rear frame hanger common Samurai stress failures, and lower gearing makes them worse. Look at the rubber mounts and the frame brackets on both sides of the case.
- [ ] **Transfer case that won't shift or sticks in neutral**
  MotorTrend lists bad transfer-case bushings that can lock the case in neutral. The usual culprit is the plastic 'shift sheet' under the lever. It's a cheap OEM or Delrin part, but check that 4WD and low range both engage.
- [ ] **Oil leaks and carburetor manners**
  MotorTrend's known trouble spots include oil leaks at the distributor, leaking brake master cylinders, fiddly carburetors on 1986–89 trucks and failing ECMs on fuel-injected ones. A clean cold start and a steady idle are worth a lot.
- [ ] **Quality of past modifications**
  Most Samurais have been modified. A well-built spring-over or engine swap saves you money; a bad one costs you. Check the steering geometry, brake lines at full droop, driveshaft angles and welds. Swapped engines may not pass emissions in some states, and Trail Tough notes that 1996-and-later 1.6 donors are OBD-II and won't be smog-legal in California.
- [ ] **Is it an automatic? It's a swap**
  Every US Samurai had a manual gearbox, so an automatic means someone swapped it in. Ask what was done and look for the paperwork.
- [ ] **Front knuckles weeping gear oil**
  Oil-soaked knuckles, loose steering and a vague front end point to worn kingpin bearings and inner axle seals. Trail Tough's rebuild kit covers both sides, and it's a common catch-up job.
- [ ] **Know which Samurai you're buying**
  For the US, 1986–89 trucks are carbureted (AMSOIL's lookup lists engine code 5) and 1990–95 are injected (code 3). The '1988½' update changed the ride, the gearing and the transfer case drain plugs. Santana and Gypsy trucks use the same basic design, but many parts differ.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Front seat belt buckle release buttons can break**
  1988–1991 · NHTSA 95V103008

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Carbureted or injected**
  AMSOIL's capacity lookups list 1986–89 US Samurais with engine code 5 and 1990–95 with engine code 3. A US truck with an automatic gearbox is a swap.
- [ ] **Early or '1988½'**
  The 1988½ update brought a new grille and wheels, new gauges and seats. Transfer case fill and drain plugs differ between 1986–88 and 1988.5–95 trucks, and the 1986–89 master cylinder is specific.
- [ ] **Narrow or wide track**
  The wide-track Samurai measures 1,300 mm front and 1,310 mm rear (1986 US brochure). Narrow SJ410/413 trucks are about 1,210 / 1,220 mm.
- [ ] **Indian-built trucks**
  Australian Sierra Stockman utes sourced from India in the 1990s carry an MG410 badge on the front fenders and a VIN starting with MA (Wikipedia).

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/suzuki/samurai/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks